

SEALED SOLUTION

Stop here until you commit.

This file reveals the investigation, the identities, and the ending. Keep it separate from the player packet.

Before continuing, write your conclusion, cite the records that support it, and name an uncertainty the file does not resolve.

Read the evidence-cited solution first. The expanded aftermath follows the original ending. It develops the human consequences; it does not supply a clue needed to solve the case.

A blank reverse follows this cover so the first answer starts on a fresh sheet when this file is printed on both sides.

The answer is overleaf.

Keep this file closed until your written reconstruction is complete.

The heir

Nell Mercer inherits. She is Ellen May Reed, born **12 September 1870**, daughter of Joseph Reed and Ada Vale. She is the eldest surviving child within the case's stated candidate bounds.

Identify Henry's sister. E01 defines Ada as Martin and Eliza Vale's daughter and Joseph Reed's wife. E07 supplies that marriage and parentage; E14 corroborates the same family at Ada's death.

Connect the birth to the claimant. E05, entry B-73, records Ellen May Reed, born 12 September 1870, to Joseph and Ada formerly Vale at 20 Mill Street. E13 matches that date, father and address and explicitly says she answers to Nell.

Follow the married name. E09 records Ellen May Reed marrying Edward Mercer, with the same father and mother. E03 has Edward and Nell Mercer in Joseph's household, with Nell's birth month and year matching. E04 places the couple at 83 Ferry Street; E02 records Nell appearing alive from that address on 14 October 1912.

Apply the rule. E05 gives Arthur's birth as 6 February 1872. Nell was born earlier. E02 establishes both claimants were alive after Henry's 1 October death. E01 gives no preference to a son or to someone still named Reed.

Why the other claims fail

Clara Whitcomb: the right surname, the wrong Ada. E08 supports her birth on 3 March 1867. It names Samuel Reed, a baker, at 4 Orchard Row, but gives only Ada Reed for the mother. E10 connects the same Clara, father, occupation and address to Ada formerly Marsh. Henry's sister is Ada Vale, married to Joseph. Clara's early date does not place her in the qualifying family.

Arthur Reed: a real child, but a younger one. E05, B-92, establishes his parentage. His C2 statement in E02 treats the burial of an Ellen as if it removed the older living child. E06 is abbreviated; its II / 19 reference leads to E11, not to a death of Ellen May.

The buried child is Lucy Ellen Reed. E11 gives her full name, death on 20 November 1868 and age of six months, sixteen days. Those fields match E05, B-41: born 4 May 1868. Ellen May, B-73, was not born until 12 September 1870. Lucy's burial therefore cannot be Ellen May's. The index and ledger are one source chain, not two independent death witnesses.

Rachel's zero births are not a contradiction. E14 reports Ada's death on 16 August 1876. E12 identifies Joseph as Ada's widower when he married Rachel Dunn on 9 February 1878. Rachel is a stepmother. E03's daughter relationship is to Joseph, the head; its zero births belongs to Rachel. Neither field says Rachel gave birth to Nell.

The family behind the claim

Henry Vale and Ada Vale are siblings, children of Martin and Eliza Vale (E01, E07, E14). Ada married Joseph Reed on 14 May 1866 (E07).

Joseph Reed + Ada Vale: Lucy Ellen Reed, 4 May 1868, died 20 November 1868; Ellen May Reed, 12 September 1870, later Nell Mercer; Arthur Joseph Reed, 6 February 1872 (E05, E11, E13, E09).

Joseph Reed + Rachel Dunn: married 9 February 1878, after Ada's death. Rachel is stepmother to the surviving children (E12, E14).

The separate Greybank branch: Samuel Reed + Ada Marsh are the recorded parents of Clara Reed, later Clara Whitcomb (E08, E10). No relationship from this branch to Henry's sister is established.

What remains unproved: the packet does not show whether Clara or Arthur knowingly lied, whether either misunderstood the records, or who first made the mistaken burial identification. A false interpretation is not evidence of a deliberate fraud. Award this part for preserving that uncertainty.

Completion check: the heir and birth date; a supported name-and-parentage chain; two losing claims explained; the burial resolved; Rachel's relationship resolved; intent left unproved. If you used hints, the case is still solved. There is no time-based score.

The executor writes Ellen May Mercer in the ledger. Below it, in smaller letters, she adds the name the woman actually uses: Nell. Only then does she pass over the keys.

Closing scene is fictional narrative, not an additional evidence source. Independent agent reasoning was used during production; no human playtime or enjoyment result is claimed.

AFTER THE CASE

The name on the receipt

After the evidence-cited solution

Ruth wrote Ellen May Mercer on the receipt and then added Nell. She wanted the formal identity and the name its owner used to occupy the same line.

Nell signed before picking up the keys. Arthur watched the pen. He had spent the morning speaking of practical matters, but when the practical act arrived he had nothing ready to say.

Clara rose first. "You found the right Ada," she said.

Nell could not tell whether it was meant as congratulations. "And yours."

Clara looked down at the reference she had copied. "Yes."

Ruth put Clara's papers into their own folder. There was no reason for the rejected claim to be remembered as a ridiculous one, or for Ada Marsh to remain merely the woman who was not Ada Vale. No evidence in the file required deliberate deceit from Clara or Arthur. Their errors still had consequences.

Arthur offered to carry Nell's packet. She almost refused because refusing would feel like winning a little more. Then she handed him the heavier part and kept the receipt herself.

"You can help me read the practical papers," she said. "You can't answer for me."

He nodded once. It was too soon to know what he would make of the distinction.

At the threshold, Nell stopped. A set of keys had become hers by the terms Henry chose. It had not arrived because Ruth liked her, because her brother had underestimated her, or because she had suffered more than Clara. The records placed Ellen May ahead of Arthur, separated her from the infant Lucy Ellen, and connected her to Ada Vale. That was the proof. The rest was what she would have to live with.

She thought about the school entry's instruction to use the full name. To its writer, it had been a small precaution against confusion. Decades later, it had helped keep her from being mistaken out of her own life.

Ruth waited while she put the receipt inside the packet. "Will you need someone to go with you?"

"I may," Nell said. "I'll ask."

She was not promising to run a mill without advice, or to become instantly generous to everyone who had irritated her. She was reserving the right to decide whom she would ask and what she would accept. Arthur held the door. Nell walked through carrying the keys, and he followed when she was ready.